two countries, previously ruled by Great Britain, had thrown off the colonial yoke only a few short decades before. Thus Indian and Pakistani leaders were loath to sign away their right to the security and status they believed nuclear weapons could bring them. They believed that Western efforts to prevent India and Pakistan from acquiring nuclear weapons resulted from a condescending, even racist, worldview. Indeed, Indian foreign minister Jaswant Singh famously labeled Western nonproliferation efforts "nuclear apartheid."[37]

Despite Western concerns, India and Pakistan pushed forward with their nuclear programs, and by the late 1980s the two countries were approaching a de facto nuclear weapons capability. Although neither country possessed a nuclear arsenal or had tested nuclear weapons, both India and Pakistan probably could have assembled nuclear devices in short order if the need to do so had arisen.[38] Some analysts believed that if such progress continued momentum toward testing and the development of overt nuclear arsenals would prove to be unstoppable.[39] Others argued that de facto nuclear capabilities afforded India and Pakistan robust deterrence; the knowledge that India and Pakistan could quickly assemble nuclear devices would make attacking them prohibitively dangerous and ensure their security. Thus, such analysts argued, India and Pakistan would have no need to test nuclear weapons and develop an overt nuclear capacity.[40]

The Indo-Pakistani nuclear tests brought these debates to an end. On May 11 and 13, 1998, India detonated five nuclear devices and the Pakistanis responded on May 28 and 30 with six nuclear explosions of their own. Clearly, de facto nuclear deterrence was insufficient to meet India and Pakistan's perceived political and security needs. Their governments wanted to ensure that their ability to inflict catastrophic damage on each other, or on any other adversary, was beyond question. Before long, however, a new controversy erupted over South Asian nuclear weapons. Now analysts argued over the impact that nuclear weapons capabilities were likely to have on the South Asian security environment. This discussion has been dominated by two main camps, labeled "proliferation optimists" and "proliferation pessimists." The optimist